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Culture (OWC): [Chagga \(FN04\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: 1906-1926

Coverage Date: 1900-1926

Place Coverage: Chagga, Tanzania

Section Title(S): 21. Age Grades

In an almost joking tone the master of ceremonies calls the participants together: "Where is the mngari, he who gets the rib piece? Why do we have to wait so long for his appearance? Why does he lie in ambush like an animal? Where is the mngari? Why does he expose us to ridicule, while he is eating the chine and the marrow? Why does he form lumps? /the meaning of the German word "klumpen" is not certain—Translator/. And you, sister of the husband, make your appearance! Appear, for today is the day of revenge (inu lja kivi). Why did you eat the hip piece, why did you eat the prime cut? Appear! Come and eat what belongs to you! But if he himself ate the hip piece and if he did not give you your share, tell him, and do not bind him the Zapfpfeil /the word makes no sense; a Zapfen is a sort of a peg, a Pfeil is an arrow—Translator/, come and tell him between age grade and elders. And if he did deny you your share, he must show you the hands of a suppliant (Bitthände), so that you can absolve him and will not have to put him in chains somewhere in an evil place."

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If there is any complaint to be made against the groom, this is the time it should be made. The master of ceremonies takes him to task and orders him to ask for forgiveness 343 and to promise an expiatory gift for which he must give a guarantor. After this, the march around the barrels begins. The procession is led by the master of ceremonies, who is followed by the maternal uncle with the fire, the mngari, the groom leaning against the mngari's shoulders, the groom's sister, and the bride leaning on the shoulder of the sister. When the march is finished the wood pile is set on fire, and if it is quickly ablaze, the natives take it as a promise of numerous children. Jubilant shouts greet the good omen. The master of ceremonies places fresh cow manure next to the burning pile to be used later on for the expiatory extinction of the fire. Then he takes a stand in front of the barrels, asks for two calabashes, and, holding one in each hand, dips them, with crossed arms, into the brew. After he has filled the calabashes he crosses his arms once more and in this position pours the content of the calabashes back into the barrels. What he had scooped up from one barrel now goes into the other barrel, and vice versa. He continues with this scooping until he has finished the following song: "Union! I unify the age grade and the elders. Union! I combine the age grade and the grandmothers! It is the wedding of the bonds. Union! I unite the Sprossen /could be "rungs of a ladder" or "shoots"—Translator/, and from this angle I can see the return. Union! I unite. My son! You [310](#) are now mature, united with the elder and with the age grade. You are not going to deride those with a barky skin. If you see an old man, you are going to help him to conceal his manhood. Do not make the day of the old man (the day of instruction) useless, the day that sits sleeping like an animal in the bush. You shall say of

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this day: why should it perish? literally: die). Today, mark this, you are set free. You are coming closer to greatness, my son, and you follow me. I unite the age grade and the elders and you, who are set free, now come to a wise rest (oja). Union! I unite young people and roosters. Union! I unite buffalos and cattle. Union! I unite he-goats and fattened animals. We want to go into hiding, we want to mix, like male dwarf goats mix. We want to go into hiding, we want to mix, like buffalos mix. We want to go into hiding, we want to mix like giraffes mix. We want to be secretive like lizards. I am the hiding. Go into hiding like the lizards, and be quiet! I am the old man of yore. I unite night and darkness. Quick, quick, before dawn comes! To prevent that we are surprised by the fire-fetcher. Quick ere he comes who takes the halter from the goats! Ere the birds give us the first drink of the morning!"

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries: ✉ hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs: ✉ hraf-support@yale.edu



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